✦ STEP 1

Topic Basics

Starting from zero: where Somaliland is, what "recognizing" a country means, and why the U.S. cares.

✧ Where is it?

Find the **Horn of Africa** on a map: the pointy part on the east side of Africa that sticks out toward Arabia.

- **Somalia** runs along that coast and is shaped like a big "7".
- **Somaliland** is the **top part of the 7**, the northern strip along the **Gulf of Aden**.
- Its neighbors are **Djibouti** (west), **Ethiopia** (south) and the rest of **Somalia** (east).
- Capital: **Hargeisa**. Main port: **Berbera**.
- Across the water is **Yemen**, where the Houthis are.

See the full map on the Neighbors & Map page.

✧ What does "recognize as a sovereign nation" mean?

Sovereign means a country rules itself, with nobody above it in charge.

Recognizing a country means the rest of the world officially says, "Yes, you are a real country." A recognized country can:

- have embassies with real ambassadors
- sign official treaties and trade deals
- join groups like the United Nations
- get loans from the World Bank and similar lenders

Somaliland already does most of what a country does: its own government, police, army, money (the Somaliland shilling), passports and elections. But on paper, almost the whole world still treats it as **part of Somalia**.

💡 **COMPARISON YOU ALREADY KNOW**

Taiwan also runs itself like a country, but most nations, including the U.S., don't officially recognize it. Somaliland is in a similar spot.

✧ Why does the U.S. care?

1. **Shipping.** Ships going to and from the Red Sea and the Suez Canal pass close to Somaliland. The Houthis in Yemen have attacked ships there.
2. **China.** Djibouti, right next door, has the main **U.S. base** in Africa and also **China's first overseas military base**.
3. **Terrorism.** The U.S. works with Somalia's government to fight **al-Shabaab**, a terrorist group linked to al-Qaeda. Somalia strongly opposes Somaliland breaking away.
4. **Taiwan.** Somaliland and Taiwan opened offices in each other's capitals in 2020, which angered China.

✧ The big idea behind the debate

AFF Reward success

Somaliland is peaceful and democratic, and it has run itself for over 30 years. Shouldn't that count?

NEG Keep things stable

If regions that want out get recognized, many countries could break apart. Upsetting Somalia and U.S. partners could also hurt the U.S.

✧ Key words

Word	Meaning
Sovereignty	A country's right to rule itself.
Recognition	Other countries officially accepting you as a country.
De facto	True in real life. Somaliland is *de facto* independent.
De jure	True on paper, by law. Somaliland is *de jure* part of Somalia.
Secession	A region breaking away from a country.
Territorial integrity	The idea that a country's borders shouldn't be broken up.
"One Somalia" policy	The official U.S. position that Somalia, including Somaliland, is one country.
Montevideo Convention	A 1933 treaty, signed by the U.S., that lists four things that make a country a country.
Horn of Africa	The region with Somalia, Somaliland, Ethiopia, Djibouti and Eritrea.
AFRICOM	U.S. Africa Command, the part of the U.S. military in charge of operations in Africa.

Somalia or Somali?

It works like *America* and *American*:

- **Somalia** is the **country**: "The U.S. works with **Somalia**."
- **Somali describes** people or things from there, or the language: "**Somali** forces," "she speaks **Somali**."
- People from Somaliland are **Somalilanders**.

> ⚠ **AUTOCORRECT ALERT**
>
> Your keyboard may change "Somalia" to "Somali." Proofread your written speech before printing it.